

OPTIONAL SKIRMISHING RULE

Commanded shot before the main engagement

Daniel J. Berger • September 2, 2026

Purpose

This optional rule represents the loose exchange of fire by commanded bodies of musketeers before the main bodies became fully engaged. It adds limited probing and reaction fire without changing the normal combat system. A skirmish may create an opportunity, but another unit must be positioned to exploit it before the dice are rolled.

Optional Rule

1. Eligibility and timing

Only an **ordered Foot unit** belonging to the active player may initiate a skirmish. Its target must be an ordered enemy unit. Leaders, artillery pieces, and trains may neither initiate nor be the target of a skirmish.

A unit in a close, train, or woods hex cannot be the target of a skirmish.

Skirmishing is permitted only during Game Turns 1–7 of the full game. It is not used in the Short Game. No skirmishes may be declared during a flash-rain turn [5.4].

An enemy unit may be selected as the target of no more than one skirmish in a March Phase.

2. Declaring a skirmish

During its normal movement, an eligible Foot unit may enter a hex adjacent to an eligible target and declare a skirmish. The unit pays the normal cost to enter the adjacent hex and must then have at least **2 MPs remaining**: 1 MP to skirmish and 1 MP to withdraw.

The player identifies the target and places a **Skirmish—Return** marker in the hex the Foot unit just vacated. That hex is reserved; no other piece may enter it before the skirmish is resolved. The skirmishing unit's movement ends immediately. The active player then completes all other ordinary movement before rolling any skirmish dice.

3. Resolving skirmishes

After all ordinary movement in the March Phase is complete, resolve declared skirmishes one at a time in any order chosen by the active player:

1. The skirmishing unit fires at its declared target, and the target makes a **Reaction Roll**. Roll one die for each unit and consult the **6+** column of the Artillery Table [17.2]. Other artillery rules do not apply: adjacency establishes eligibility, and no line of sight or range is traced.
2. Record both results, but do not apply either result yet. The two attacks are simultaneous; a result suffered by one unit never cancels its own fire.

3. Return the skirmishing Foot unit to the marked hex. This withdrawal costs the reserved 1 MP regardless of terrain.
4. Apply both recorded results simultaneously, then remove the marker. A **Dd** result disrupts an ordered target; a dash has no effect.

A Reaction Roll is not always literal return fire. For Foot it represents return musketry; for Horse it may represent pistol or carbine fire, or a short countercharge. Horse may be a target, but may not initiate a skirmish.

4. After the exchange

The March Phase ends after all marked skirmishes have been resolved. No unit may move in response to a skirmish result. Proceed to the active player's Combat Phase normally. Thus, a unit already positioned to attack may exploit a newly disrupted enemy, but the active player cannot first see the result and then move up an attacker.

Temporary adjacency created by the skirmishing unit has no effect after it withdraws. All mandatory-attack requirements are determined from the units' positions at the beginning of the ensuing Combat Phase [9.0].

Skirmish Fire: 6+ Column

Die Roll	Result
1	Dd—target disrupted
2–6	——no effect

Rules References

Movement and MP limits: [8.1–8.8]. Artillery die-roll procedure and table: [7.0], [17.2]. Disruption: [11.8]. Short Game: [16.0].

Design Intent

The idea is to show commanded musketeers feeling out the enemy before the main fight. Because the dice come after movement, any Horse waiting to exploit a disruption must be committed first. Most exchanges will do nothing; occasionally one will open a useful opportunity. That is about as much weight as this small rule should carry.

Illustrated Example of Play

All illustrated hexes are clear terrain. During an Allied March Phase, **1/Crfrd** will skirmish with **Urry**. Cromwell's Heavy Horse is nearby, but its movement must be committed before the skirmish dice are rolled.

Before: the Allied player plans the probe

Royalist front

Urry 3-2-8

Tillier 10-2-4

1/Crfrd 18-2-3

Cromwell 7-4-8

Allied front

The Allied player intends to send 1/Crfrd forward against Urry while moving Cromwell's Heavy Horse adjacent to Urry. Tillier remains nearby but is not the declared skirmish target.

The Allied player is making a commitment: Cromwell must move into attack position before anyone knows whether Urry will be disrupted.

During: movement is completed, then fire is exchanged

fire / react

Urry 3-2-8

Tillier 10-2-4

1/Crfrd 18-2-3

Cromwell 7-4-8

advance return

SKIRMISH

move

1/Crfrd pays its normal entry cost, then reserves 2 MPs. The Skirmish—Return marker occupies its former hex. Cromwell completes his move adjacent to Urry; all other Allied movement then ends.

Both sides now roll on the 6+ column:

- 1/Crfrd rolls **1: Dd** against Urry.
- Urry's Reaction Roll is **4**: no effect against 1/Crfrd.

The results are recorded but not yet applied.

After: withdraw first, then apply the results

URRY DISRUPTED

Urry 2-2-2

Tillier 10-2-4

1/Crfrd 18-2-3

Cromwell 7-4-8

NEXT: COMBAT PHASE

Before either result takes effect, 1/Crfrd returns to the marked hex. The marker is removed. The recorded results are then applied simultaneously: 1/Crfrd remains ordered and Urry is flipped to its disrupted side.

The Allied Combat Phase now begins. Cromwell's Heavy Horse is already adjacent and must attack normally. It may exploit Urry's disruption because its charge was positioned before the successful skirmish roll. No additional Allied movement is permitted.

The diagrams illustrate timing, not a historical deployment or exact map position.